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Babur’s Home

‘I have not written all this to complain I have simply written the truth. I do not intend by what I have written to compliment myself: I have simply set down exactly what happened.’

—Babur

Babur was just twelve during the month of Ramzan of AH 899 (June of AD 1494) when he became the de facto ruler of the country of Ferghana. Perhaps, at such a tender age, he could not even very well understand the pain of losing his father. Nor do I assume that he saw so well the weight of the responsibility to be a fatherly figure to the land of Ferghana. The populace loved his father. And why not, when he had done so much good in his reign?

His father Umar Shaikh Mīrzā II had met with an unfortunate accident while tending to pigeons in the badly constructed dovecote. It toppled into the canyon below the palace, flowing into the river with his pet pigeons. He died and Babur’s fate to become king of chessboard got scripted.

By that period Ferghana’s habitation was well-settled. On the east existed Kashghar; on the west, Samarkand; on the south, the mountains of the Badakhshan border. In the early ages before Babur, there existed towns such as Almaligh, Almaty and Yangi (Yany). The local folklore mentioned Yangi as Taraz. In that period, those places remained desolate without a settled population. The city had seen massive destruction at the hands of Mongols.[1] It seemed to have attained restoration at the hands of Aūzbegs.

Back then Ferghana was a small country. Fruits and grains grew there in abundance. It was surrounded by mountains in all directions except on the western periphery, towards Khujand and Samarkand. This was the only probable orifice through which enemies could make a passage into the Ferghana. The Syr River[2] entered Babur’s land from the north-east. Turning westward, it passed along the northern edge of Khujand, kissing the